

Lecture 3. Maps

PUBH 6199: Visualizing Data with R, Summer 2026

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2026-06-02



Time to start thinking about your final project



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Be prepared to share your project idea via a 2-min pitch in lab 4 next week (June 11th).

- Project idea
- Research questions
- Potential data sources
- Format preference and anticipated visualizations

See [course website](#) for project details and deadlines.



Outline for today

- **Types of maps for spatial data**
- Map design considerations (color, projection, legend)
- R packages for mapping
- Static maps with **tmap**
- Interactive maps with **leaflet**
- Accessing spatial data with **tigris** and **tidycensus**



Types of Maps for Spatial Data

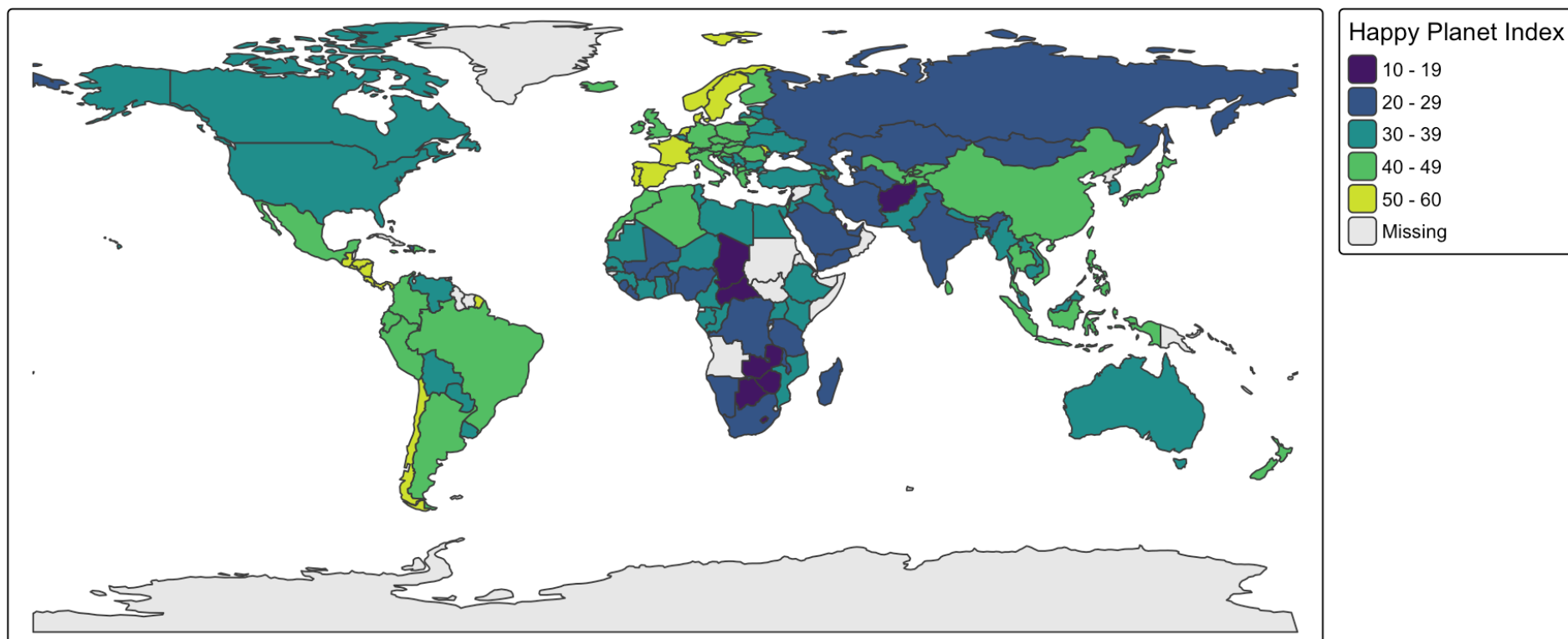
1. Choropleth Map

- Display the spatial distribution of a variable across divided geographical areas
- Best for **normalized** data (e.g., rates)
- Variable encoding: **color** (intensity or hue)



Example: Choropleth

```
1 library(tmap)
2 data("World")
3 tm_shape(World) +
4   tm_polygons("HPI", palette = "viridis", title = "Happy Planet Index")
```



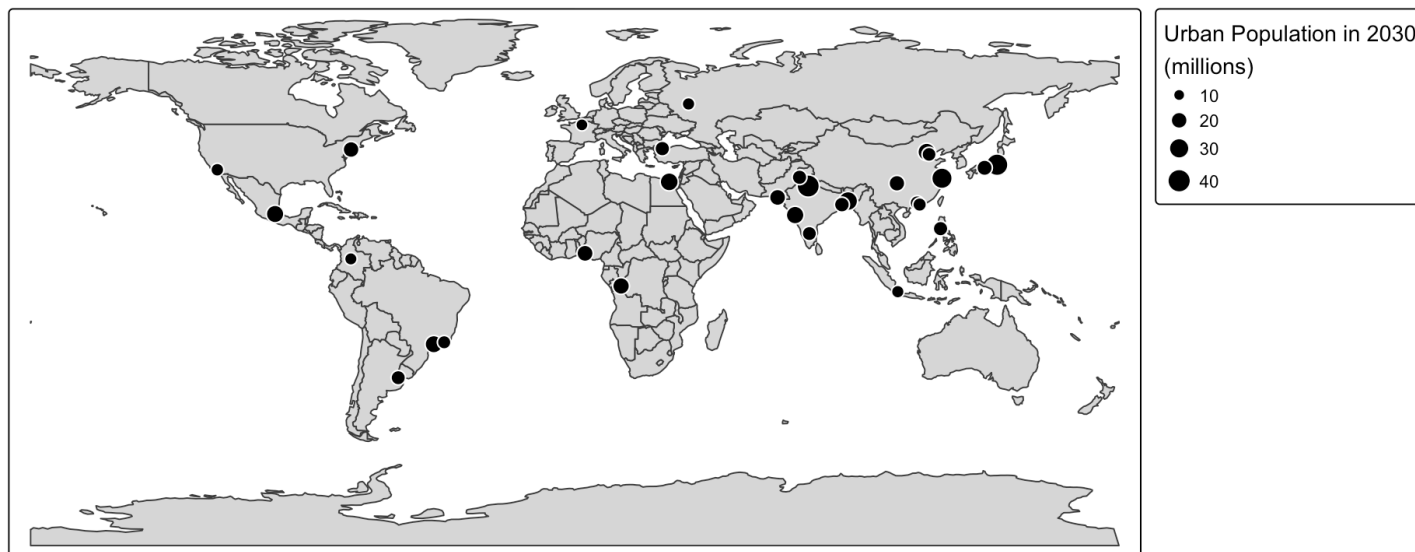
2. Point Map

- Each point represents a location
- Can show locations of events, facilities, cases
- Variable encoding: **color**, **shape**, **size**



Example: Point Map

```
1 library(tidyverse)
2 library(spData)
3 library(tmap)
4 data(urban_agglomerations)
5 urb_2030 <- urban_agglomerations |> filter(year == 2030)
6 tm_shape(World) +
7   tm_polygons() +
8   tm_shape(urb_2030) +
9   tm_symbols(fill = "black", col = "white", size = "population_millions",
10             size.legend = tm_legend(title = "Urban Population in 2030\n(millions)"))
```



3. Heat Map (Density)

- Visualizes concentration of events
- Uses kernel density estimation or hex bins
- Variable encoding: **color** (intensity)

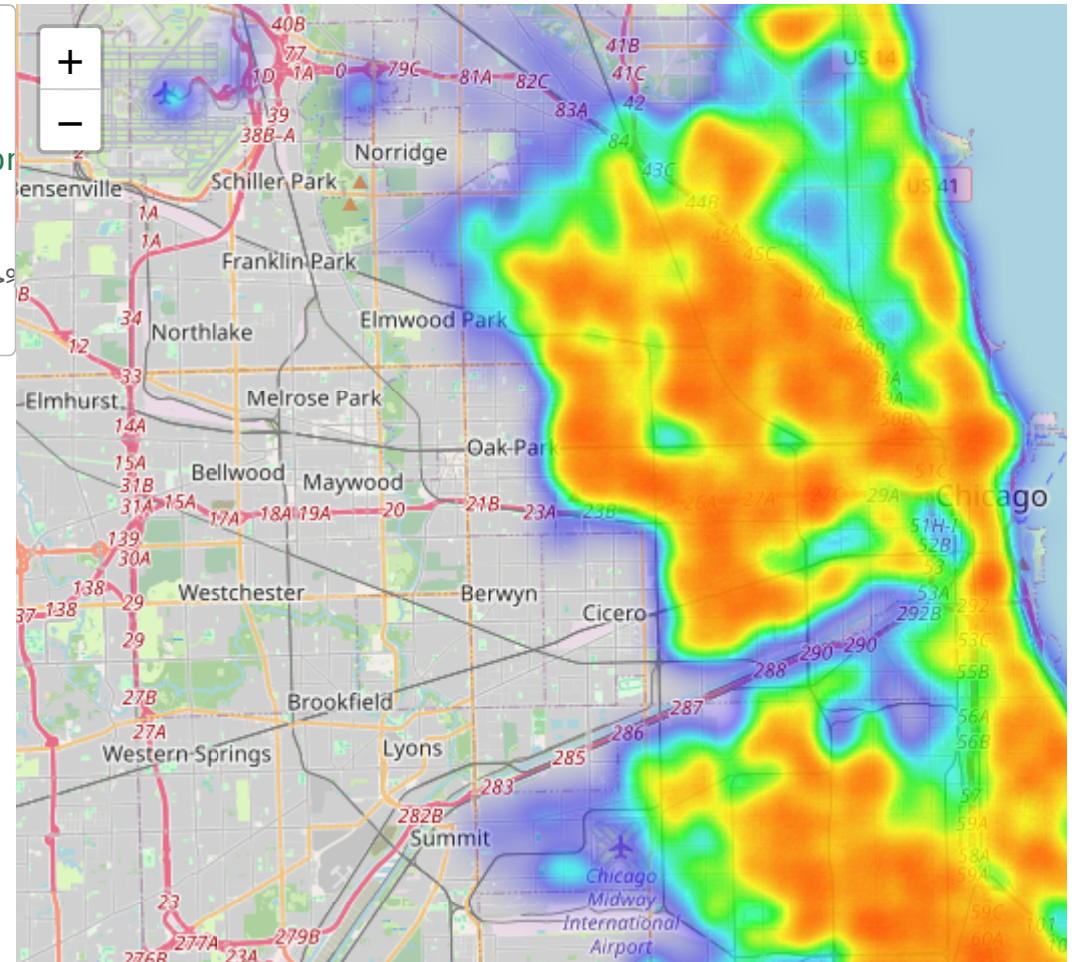


Example: Heat map with `leaflet.extras`

```

1 library(leaflet)
2 library(leaflet.extras)
3 thefts_coords <- read_csv("data/thefts_coords.csv")
4 thefts_sf <- st_as_sf(thefts_coords, coords = c("lon", "lat"))
5 leaflet(thefts_sf) %>%
6   addProviderTiles("OpenStreetMap") %>%
7   addHeatmap(blur = 15, max = 0.05, radius = 10) %>%
8   setView(lng = -87.6298, lat = 41.8781, zoom = 11)

```



4. Faceted Map

- Create small multiples to compare across categories
- Great for time series or group comparisons

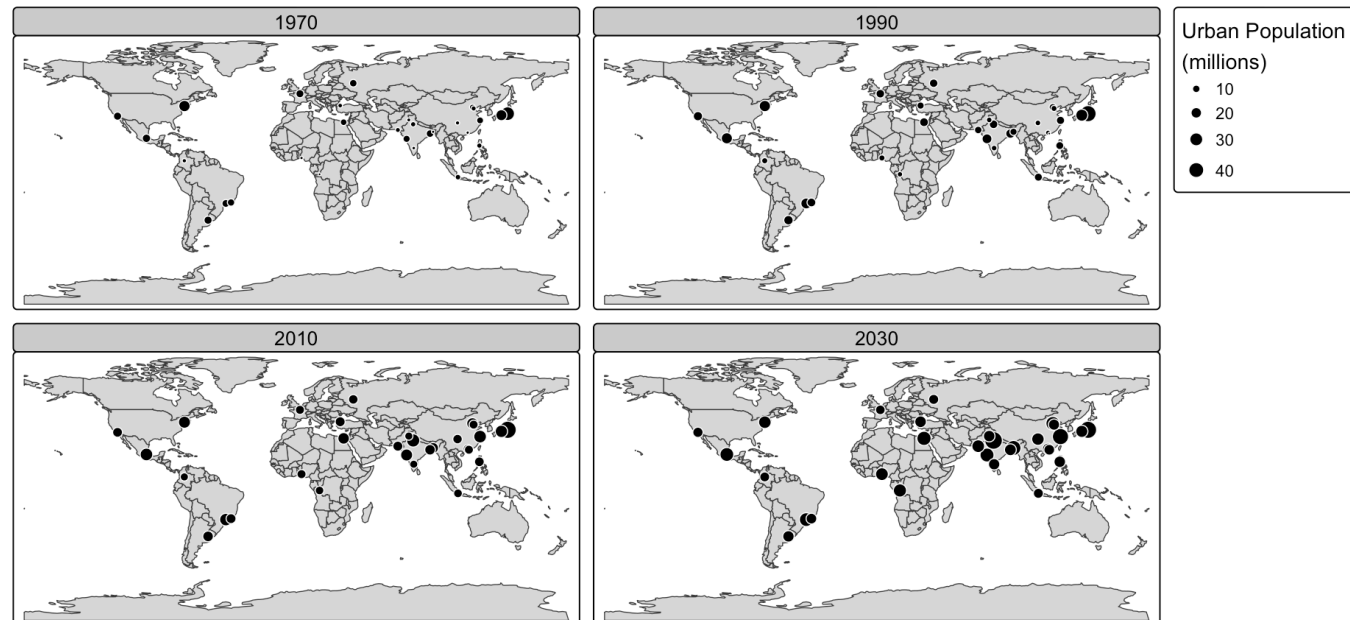


Example: Faceted Map

```

1 library(tidyverse)
2 library(spData)
3 library(tmap)
4 data(urban_agglomerations)
5 urb_1970_2030 <- urban_agglomerations |> filter(year %in% c(1970, 1990, 2010, 2030))
6 tm_shape(World) +
7   tm_polygons() +
8   tm_shape(urb_1970_2030) +
9   tm_symbols(fill = "black", col = "white", size = "population_millions",
10             size.legend = tm_legend(title = "Urban Population\n(millions)")) +
11   tm_facets(by = "year", ncol = 2)

```

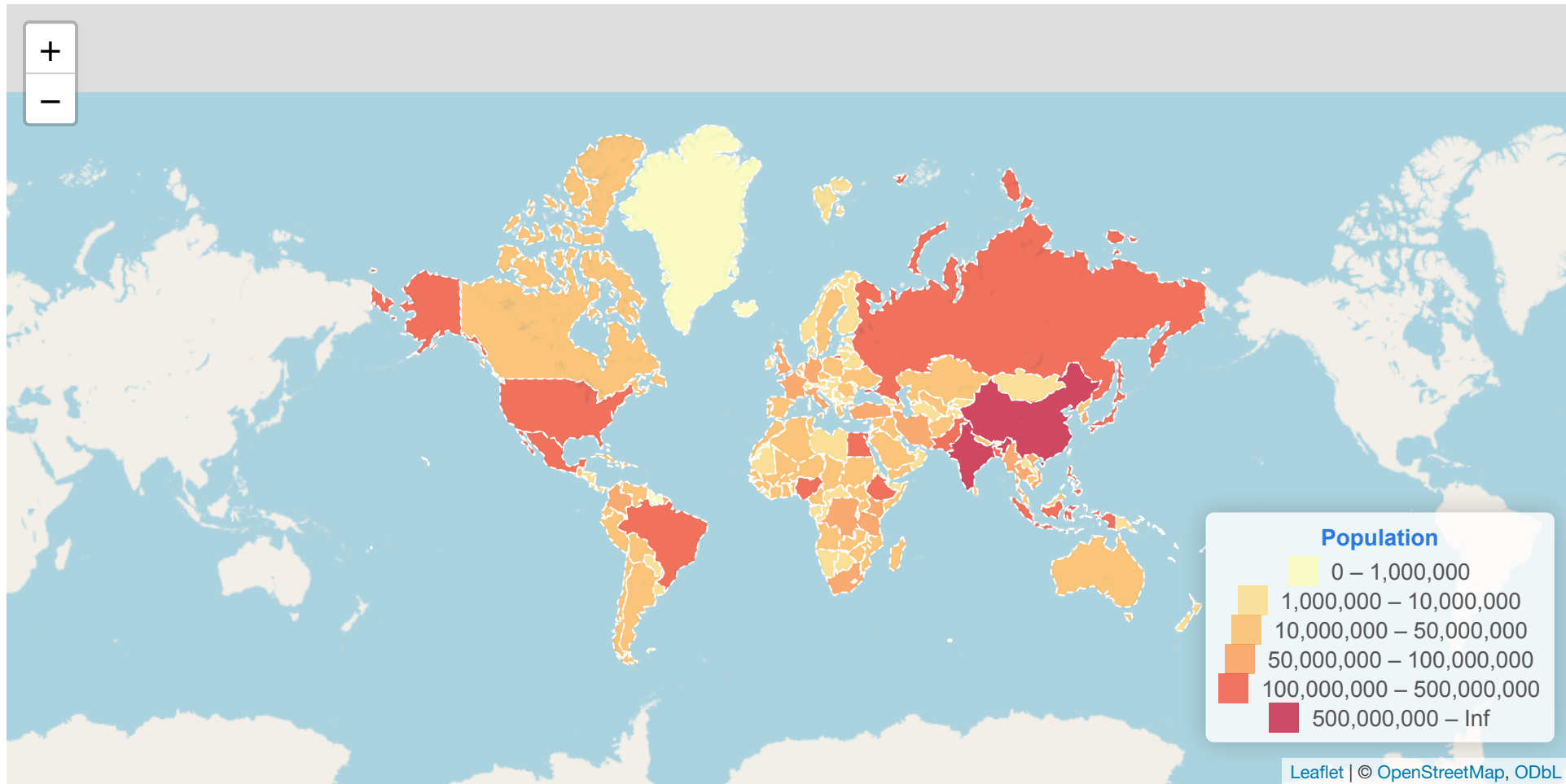


5. Interactive Map

- Enable zooming, hovering, filtering
- Useful for dashboards, web apps



Example: Interactive Map



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Color Choices for Maps

- **Sequential** palettes for ordered values
- **Diverging** palettes for above/below mean
- **Qualitative** for categories

QUANTITATIVE COLOR SCALES

SEQUENTIAL & UNCLASSED



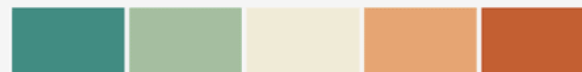
SEQUENTIAL & CLASSED



DIVERGING & UNCLASSED



DIVERGING & CLASSED



QUALITATIVE COLOR SCALES

CATEGORICAL



Source: [Which color scale to use when visualizing data](#), by Lisa Charlotte Muth.

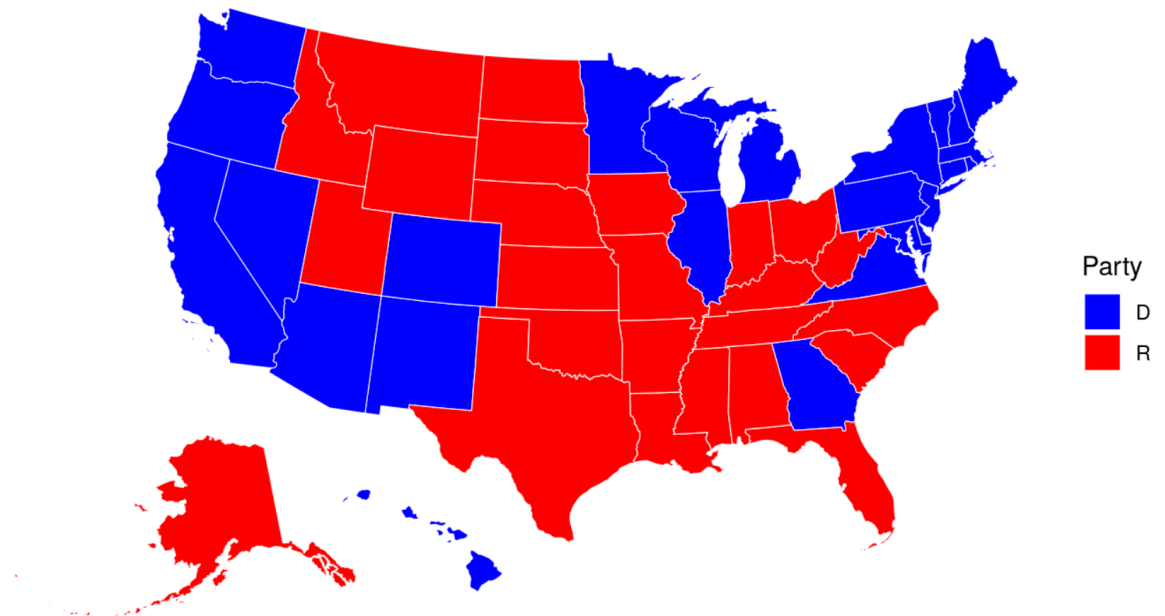
Categorical scales

- Use distinct **hues** for different categories
- Limit to **no more than 7 hues**

QUALITATIVE COLOR SCALES



2020 US presidential election results by state



Note: Nebraska and Maine split electoral college votes by congressional district

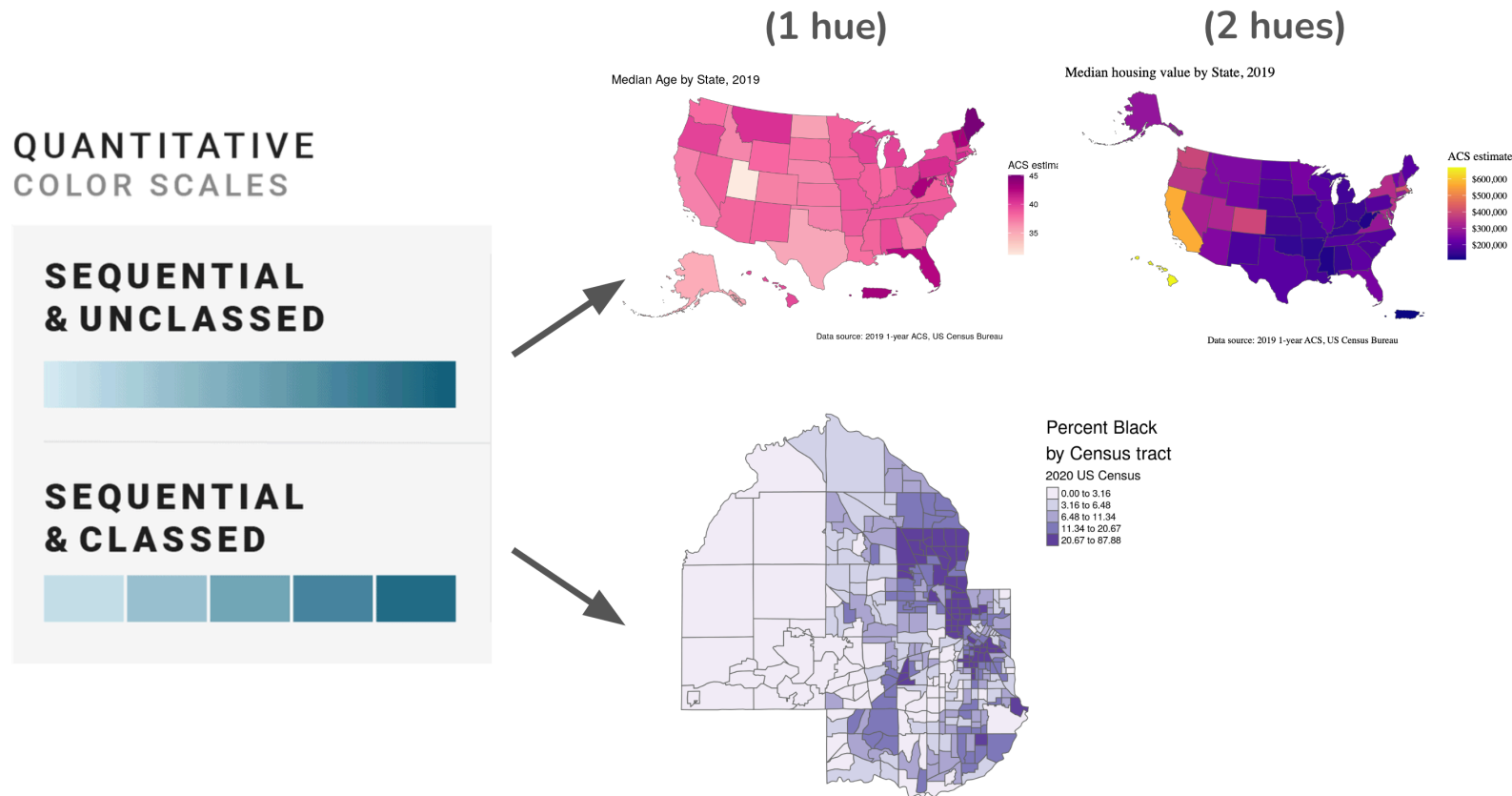
Source: [Analyzing US Census Data](#), by Kyle Walker

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Sequential Scales

- Map value to color on a continuum, based on both **intensity** and **hue**
- Use for ordered data (e.g., population, income)



Source: [Analyzing US Census Data](#), by Kyle Walker

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Diverging Scales

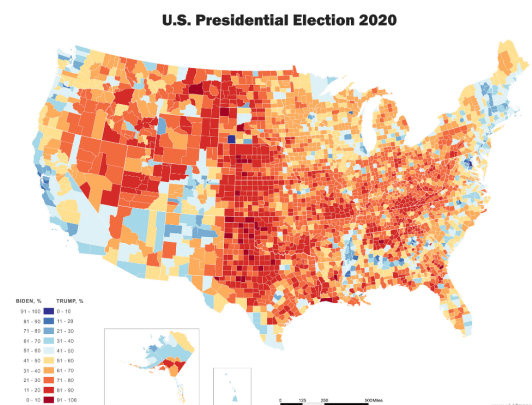
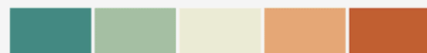
- Use for data with a **meaningful midpoint** (e.g., above/below average)
- Two contrasting colors with a **neutral midpoint** (e.g., white/light gray)

QUANTITATIVE COLOR SCALES

DIVERGING & UNCLASSED



DIVERGING & CLASSED

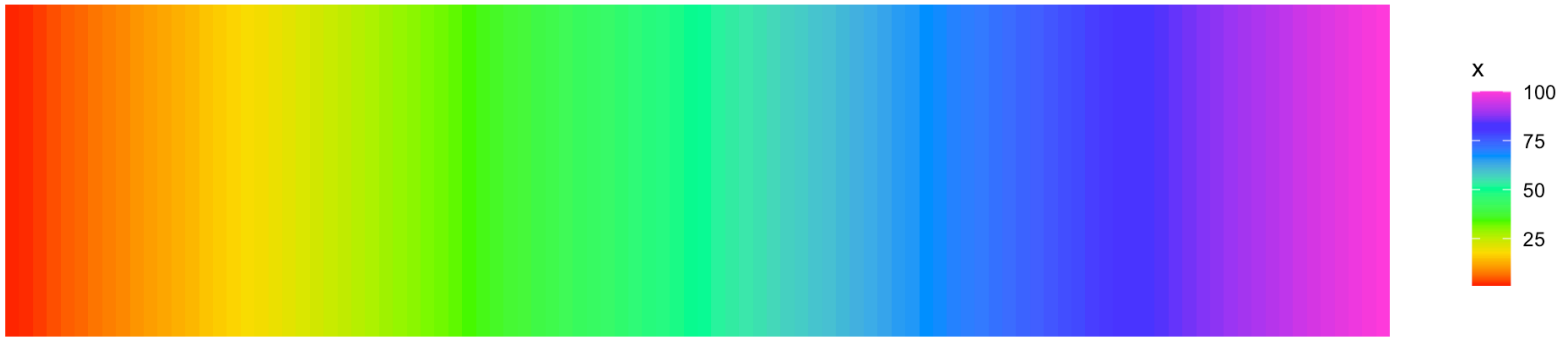


Source: [2020 U.S. Election Mapped](#), by Vivid Maps

Avoid Misleading Colors

- Don't use rainbow: not perceptually uniform

Rainbow (Perceptually Nonlinear)



Viridis (Perceptually Uniform)



- Consider accessibility (color-blind safe palettes)
- Avoid encoding meaning with non-intuitive colors

Map Projections

- A projection distorts shape, area, distance, or direction
- Use equal-area projections for choropleths

Why all world maps are wrong

Vox



Watch on

Common Projections in R

Use Case	Recommended Projection	EPSG Code
Equal-area choropleths	Albers Equal Area	5070
Interactive maps	Web Mercator	3857
Global perspective	Robinson or Winkel Tripel	54030 / 54042
Local detail (U.S.)	NAD83 / State Plane	varies

Use `st_transform()` to convert:

```
1 my_data <- sf::st_transform(my_data, crs = 5070)
```

In `tmap`:

- In static mode: all layers are reprojected to match the first layer.
- In interactive mode: all layers are projected to EPSG:3857.

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R Ecosystem for Mapping

- **Data handling:** `sf`, `sp`
- **Thematic mapping:** `tmap`, `ggplot2`, `cartography`
- **Basemaps & interactivity:** `leaflet`, `mapview`, `ggmap`
- **Shapefiles:** `rgdal`, `rmapshaper`
- **Data access:** `tigris`, `tidycensus`



{sf}: simple features

The `{sf}` package is the **standard way to work with vector spatial data in R**. It replaces older tools like `{sp}` with a **simple, tidy-friendly** interface.

Key Features of `{sf}`

- Stores **geometry + attributes** in a single `data.frame`-like object
- Built on **simple features** standard (ISO 19125-1)
- Fully compatible with **`dplyr`, `ggplot2`, `tmap`**
- Uses `sfc` column to store spatial information (e.g., points, polygons)

Simple feature collection with 100 features and 6 fields
 Geometry type: MULTIPOLYGON
 Dimension: XY
 Bounding box: xmin: -84.32385 ymin: 33.88199 xmax: -75.45698 ymax: 36.58965
 Geodetic CRS: NAD27
 First 3 features:

	BIR74	SID74	NWBIR74	BIR79	SID79	NWBIR79	geometry
1	1091	1	10	1364	0	19	MULTIPOLYGON (((-81.47276 3...
2	487	0	10	542	3	12	MULTIPOLYGON (((-81.23989 3...
3	3188	5	208	3616	6	260	MULTIPOLYGON (((-80.45634 3...

Simple feature
 Simple feature geometry list-column (sfc)
 Simple feature geometry (sfg)



Outline for today

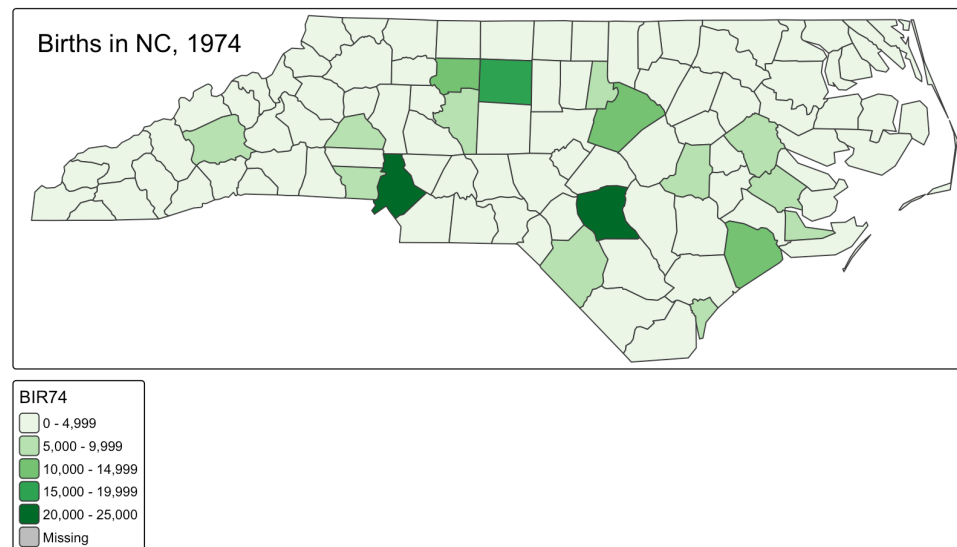
- Types of maps for spatial data
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Static Mapping with **tmap**

- Similar to `ggplot2`, based on “the grammar of graphics”
- Supports both static and interactive modes
- Excellent for quick, polished maps, sensible defaults

```
1 library(tmap)
2 tmap_mode("plot")
3 nc <- st_read("data/nc.shp", quiet = TRUE) # nc is an `sf` object
4 tm_shape(nc) + # defines input data
5   tm_polygons("BIR74", palette = "Greens") + # mapping data to aesthetics
6   tm_layout(title = "Births in NC, 1974")
```



How `{tmap}` works?

`{tmap}` adopts an intuitive approach to map-making: the addition operator `+` adds a new layer, followed by `tm_*()`:

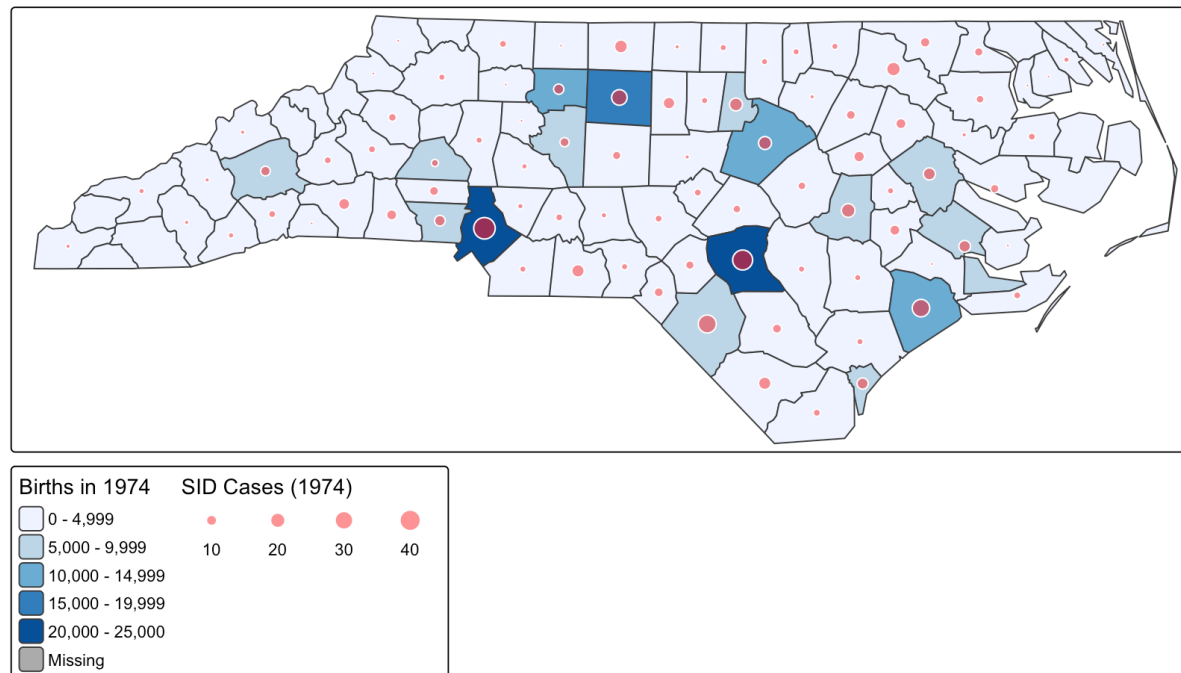
- `tm_fill()`: shaded areas for (multi)polygons
- `tm_borders()`: border outlines for (multi)polygons
- `tm_polygons()`: both, shaded areas and border outlines for (multi)polygons
- `tm_lines()`: lines for (multi)linestrings
- `tm_symbols()`: symbols for (multi)points, (multi)linestrings, and (multi)polygons
- `tm_raster()`: colored cells of raster data (there is also `tm_rgb()` for rasters with three layers)
- `tm_text()`: text information for (multi)points, (multi)linestrings, and (multi)polygons



Adding layers in {tmap}

- `tm_polygons()`: for choropleth maps
- `tm_symbols()`: for point data, size and color can represent different variables

```
1 # Create the map: choropleth + bubbles
2 tm_shape(nc) +
3   tm_polygons("BIR74", palette = "brewer.blues", title = "Births in 1974") +
4   tm_symbols(size = "SID74", col = "red", alpha = 0.5, border.col = "white",
5             title.size = "SID Cases (1974)")
```



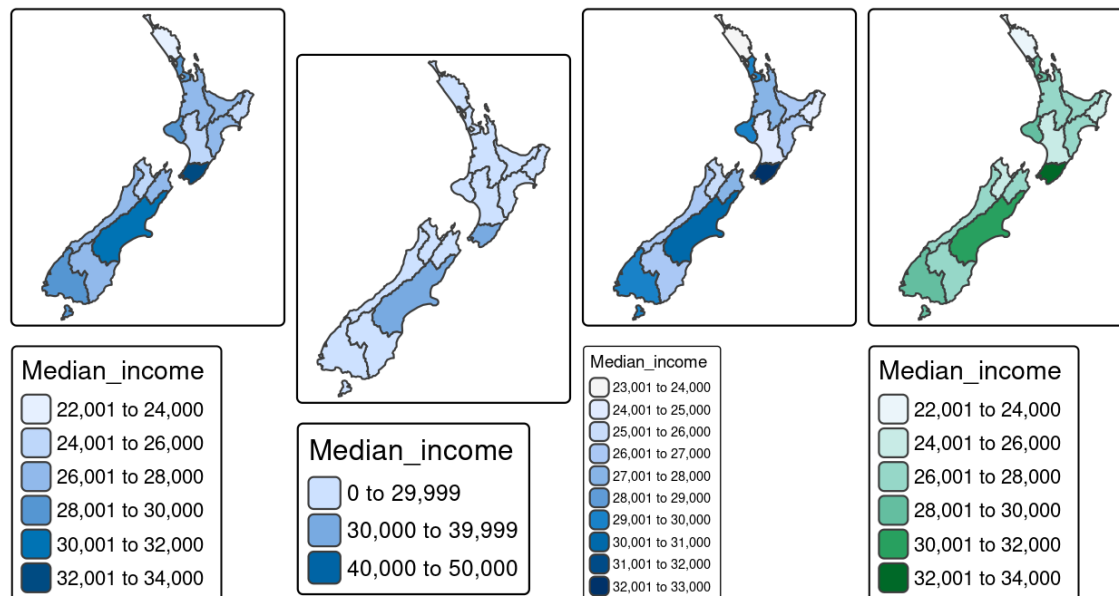
Scale

Scales control how the values are represented on the map and in the legend, and can have a major impact on how spatial variability is portrayed

```

1 tm_shape(nz) + tm_polygons(fill = "Median_income")
2 tm_shape(nz) + tm_polygons(fill = "Median_income",
3                             fill.scale = tm_scale(breaks = c(0, 30000, 40000, 50000)))
4 tm_shape(nz) + tm_polygons(fill = "Median_income",
5                             fill.scale = tm_scale(n = 10))
6 tm_shape(nz) + tm_polygons(fill = "Median_income",
7                             fill.scale = tm_scale(values = "BuGn"))

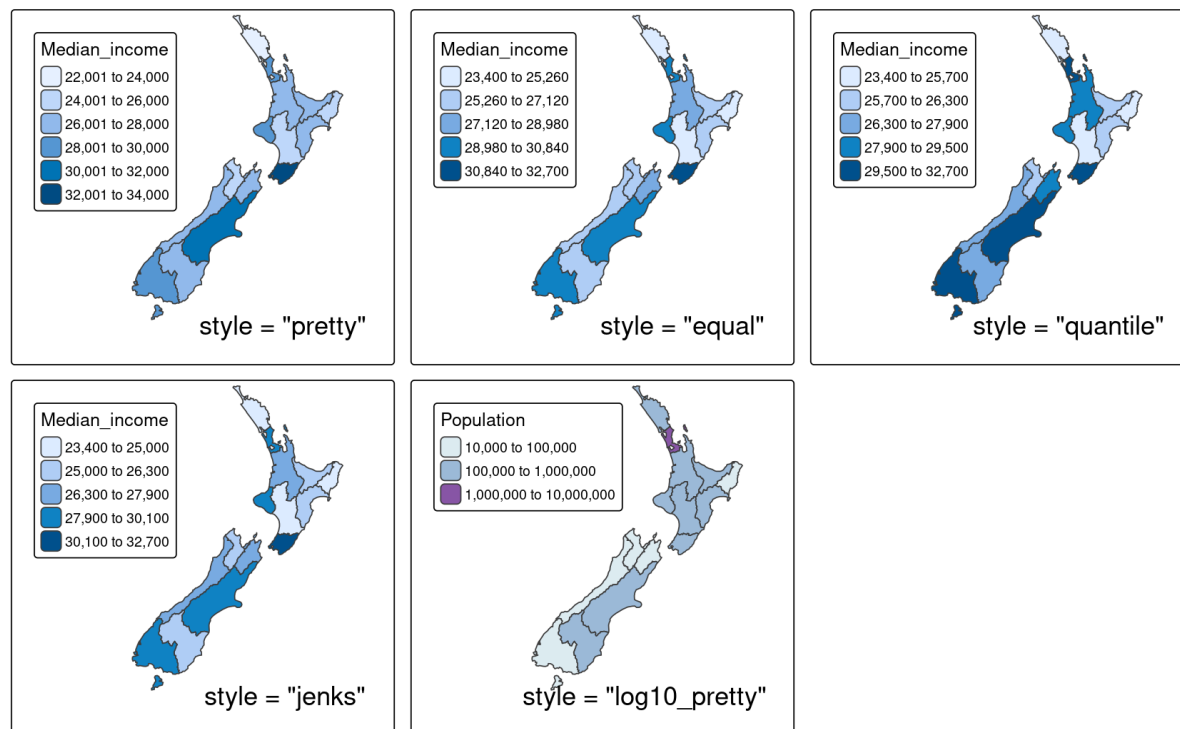
```



Style options for classifying map data

`tm_scale_intervals(style = "pretty")`:

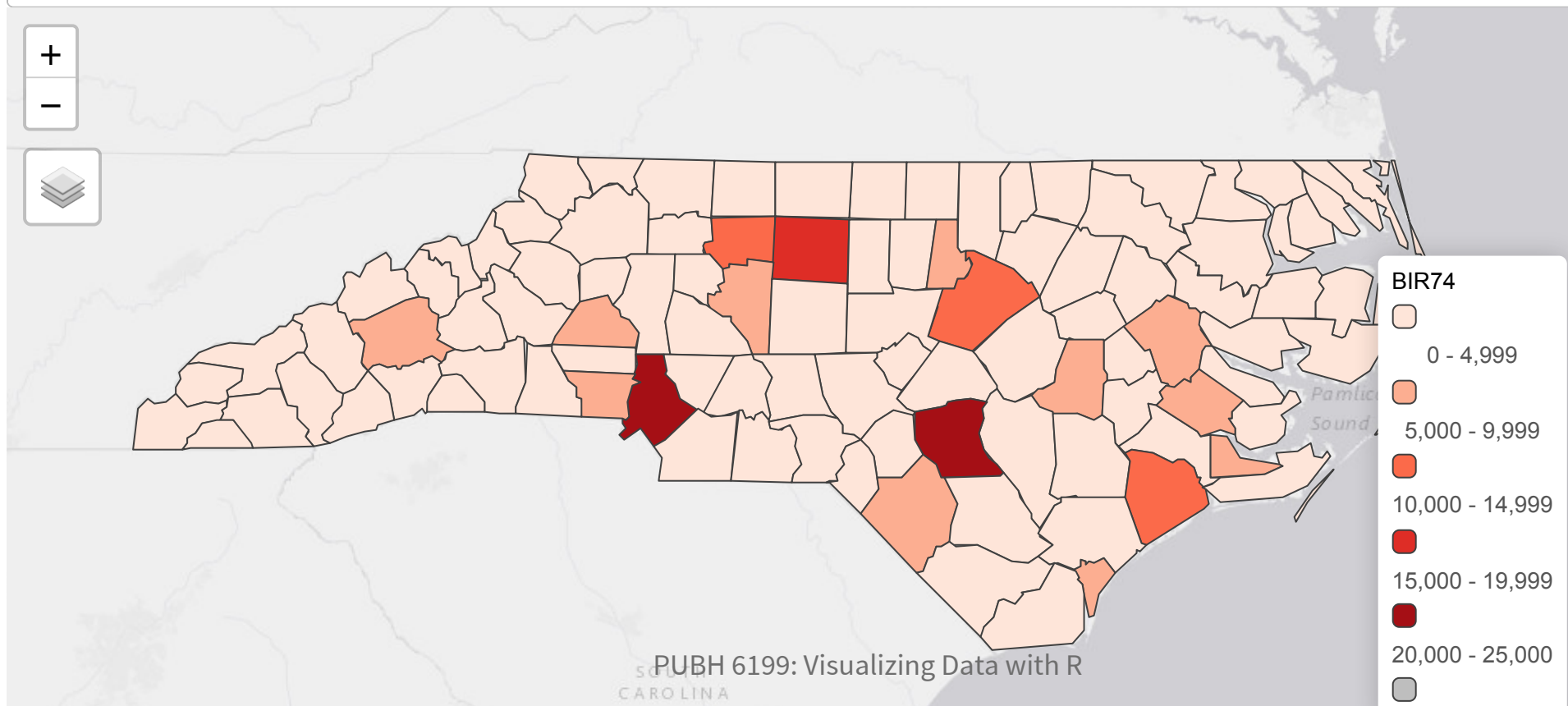
- **“pretty”**: Rounded, evenly spaced breaks (**default**).
- **“equal”**: Equal-width bins; poor fit for skewed data — may hide variation.
- **“quantile”**: Equal count per bin; be careful with wide bin ranges.
- **“jenks”**: Optimizes natural groupings; can be slow with large datasets.
- **“log10_pretty”**: Log-scaled breaks; only appropriate for right-skewed, positive values.



Switch to interactive {tmap}

A unique feature of {tmap} is its ability to create static and interactive maps using the same code. Maps can be viewed interactively at any point by switching to view mode, using the command `tmap_mode("view")`

```
1 tmap_mode("view")
2 tm_shape(nc) +
3   tm_polygons("BIR74", palette = "brewer.reds")
```



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Interactive Mapping with `{leaflet}` in R

- `{leaflet}` is the most widely used interactive mapping package in R.
- It provides a relatively low-level interface to the Leaflet.js JavaScript library leafletjs.com.
- Maps start with `leaflet()` and use pipeable layers like `addTiles()`, `addCircles()`, and `addPolygons()`.

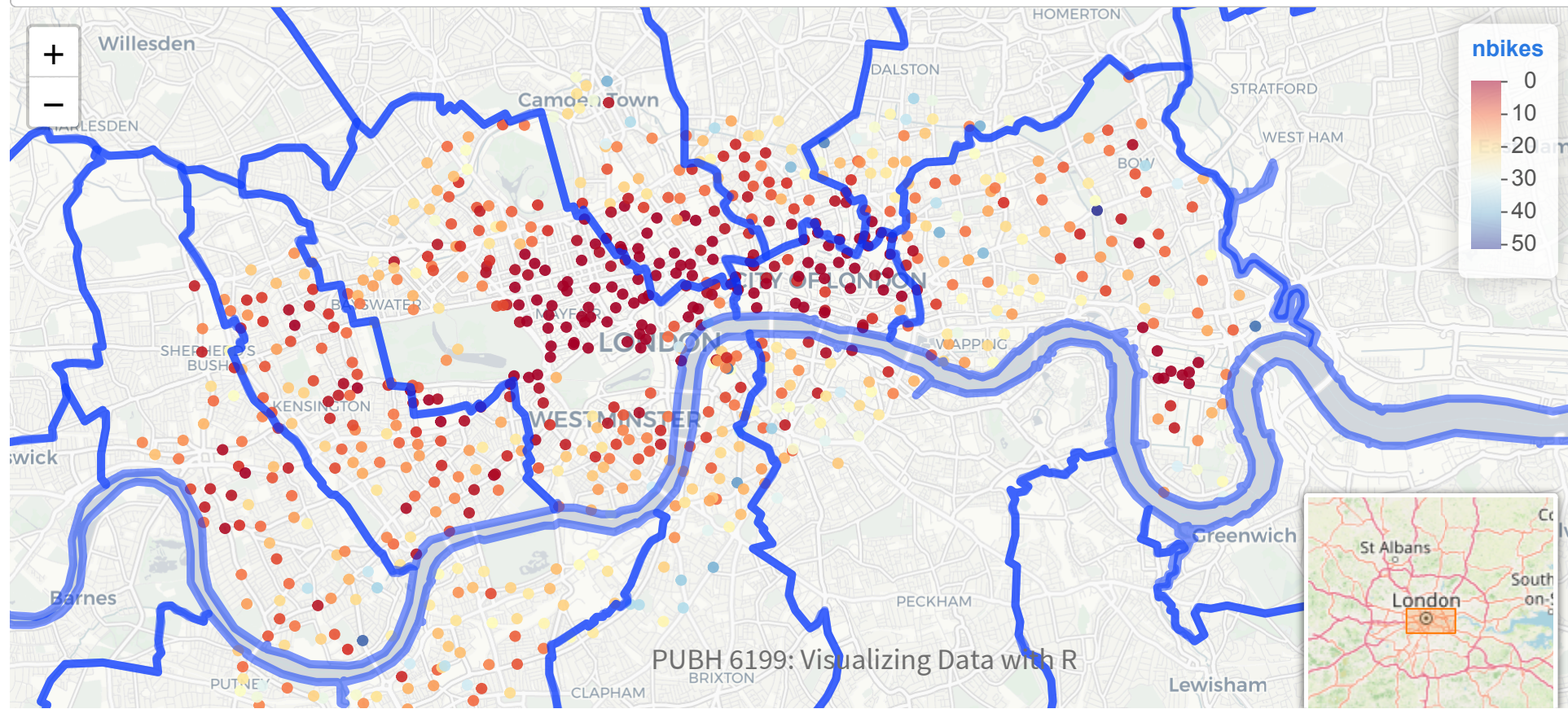


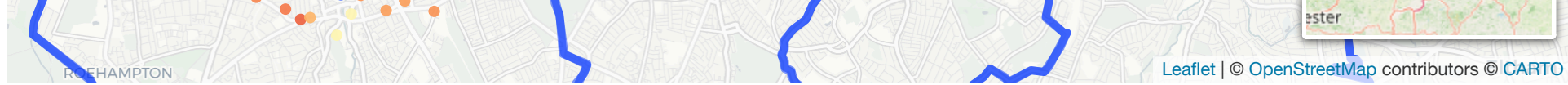
Example `leaflet` Map

```

1 pal <- colorNumeric("RdYlBu", domain = cycle_hire$nbikes)
2 # cycle_hire is an `sf` object with columns: name, nbikes, geometry, built-in data from spData
3 leaflet(cycle_hire) |>
4   addProviderTiles(providers$CartoDB.Positron) |>
5   addCircles(col = ~pal(nbikes), opacity = 0.9) |>
6   # lnd is a London boroughs shapefile
7   addPolygons(data = lnd, fill = FALSE) |>
8   addLegend(pal = pal, values = ~nbikes) |>
9   setView(lng = -0.1, lat = 51.5, zoom = 12) |>
10  addMiniMap()

```





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Getting Data with **tigris**

The `{tigris}` package provides access to U.S. Census Bureau geographic data. Shapefiles downloaded using `{tigris}` will be loaded as a simple features (sf) object with geometries.



- A **shapefile** is a vector data file format commonly used for geospatial analysis.
- Shapefiles contain information for spatially describing features (e.g. points, lines, polygons), as well as any associated attribute information.
- You can find / download shapefiles online (e.g. from the US Census Bureau), or depending on the tools available, access them via packages (like we're doing today).

Getting U.S. County Shapefiles

Entire US

```
1 library(tigris)
2 library(sf)
3 counties <- counties(state = NULL, cb = TRUE, progress = FALSE)
4 # Use `cb = TRUE` for simplified geometries
5 glimpse(counties)
```

Rows: 3,235

Columns: 13

```
$ STATEFP    <chr> "01", "01", "01", "10", "01", "01",
"04", "05", "05", "05",...
$ COUNTYFP   <chr> "069", "023", "113", "005", "071",
"089", "015", "017", "12...
$ COUNTYNS   <chr> "00161560", "00161537", "00161583",
"00217269", "00161561",...
$ GEOIDFQ    <chr> "05000000US01069", "05000000US01023",
"05000000US01113", "0500...
$ GEOID      <chr> "01069", "01023", "01113", "10005",
"01071", "01089", "0401...
$ NAME       <chr> "Houston", "Choctaw", "Russell",
"Sussex", "Jackson", "Madi...
$ NAMELSAD   <chr> "Houston County", "Choctaw County",
"Russell County", "Suss...
$ STUSPS     <chr> "AL", "AL", "AL", "DE", "AL", "AL",
"AZ", "AR", "AR", "AR",...
$ STATE_NAME <chr> "Alabama", "Alabama", "Alabama",
"Delaware", "Alabama", "Al...
```

One state

```
1 library(tigris)
2 library(sf)
3 counties_md <- counties(state = "Maryland", cb = TRUE, progress = FALSE)
4 # Use `cb = TRUE` for simplified geometries
5 glimpse(counties_md)
```

Rows: 24

Columns: 13

```
$ STATEFP    <chr> "24", "24", "24", "24", "24", "24",
"24", "24", "24", "24",...
$ COUNTYFP   <chr> "005", "019", "017", "015", "041",
"037", "039", "011", "03...
$ COUNTYNS   <chr> "01695314", "00596495", "01676992",
"00596115", "00592947",...
$ GEOIDFQ    <chr> "05000000US24005", "05000000US24019",
"05000000US24017", "0500...
$ GEOID      <chr> "24005", "24019", "24017", "24015",
"24041", "24037", "2403...
$ NAME       <chr> "Baltimore", "Dorchester",
"Charles", "Cecil", "Talbot", "S...
$ NAMELSAD   <chr> "Baltimore County", "Dorchester
County", "Charles County", ...
$ STUSPS     <chr> "MD", "MD", "MD", "MD", "MD", "MD",
"MD", "MD", "MD", "MD",...
$ STATE_NAME <chr> "Maryland", "Maryland", "Maryland",
"Maryland", "Maryland",...
```



Getting Census Data with **tidycensus**

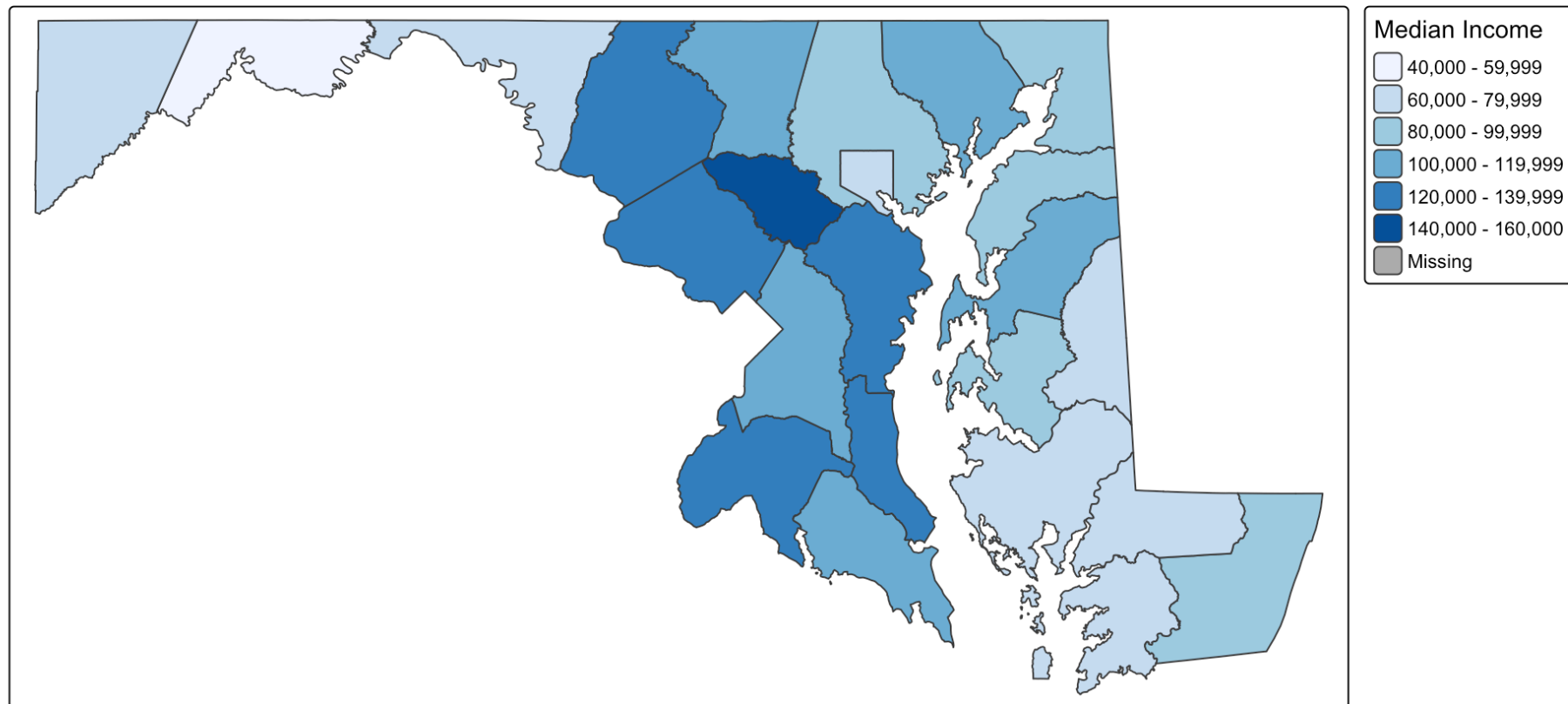
```
1 library(tidycensus)
2 # add census api key
3 invisible(
4   census_api_key(Sys.getenv("CENSUS_API_KEY"), install = TRUE, overwrite = TRUE)
5 )
6 options(tigris_use_cache = TRUE)
7 income_md <- get_acs(geography = "county",
8   state = "MD",
9   variables = "B19013_001",
10   geometry = FALSE,
11   show_progress = FALSE)
```

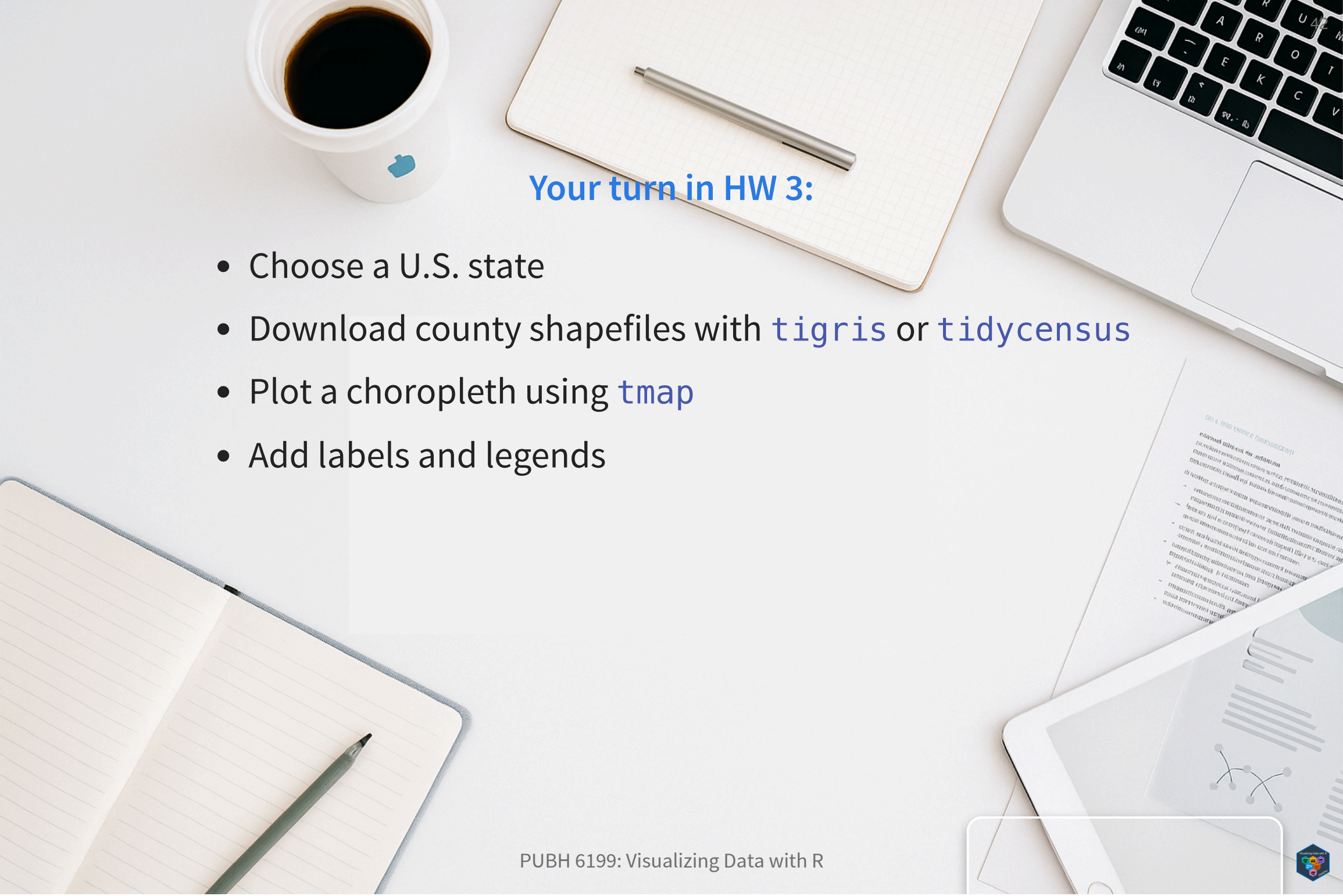
Follow [this tutorial](#) on how to get started with `{tidycensus}` packages. Remember to add your `.Renvirom` to `.gitignore` so that you do not share your API keys.



Plotting Census Data

```
1 tmap_mode("plot")
2 income_md <- counties_md |>
3   left_join(income_md, by = c("GEOID" = "GEOID")) # join the income data to the counties
4 tm_shape(income_md) +
5   tm_polygons("estimate", palette = "Blues", title = "Median Income")
```



A top-down view of a workspace. In the top left is a white cup of black coffee. Next to it is a small notebook with a grid pattern and a silver pen. To the right is a laptop showing a keyboard. In the bottom left is an open lined notebook with a green pen. In the bottom right is a tablet displaying a network diagram. The background is a light-colored desk.

Your turn in HW 3:

- Choose a U.S. state
- Download county shapefiles with `tigris` or `tidycensus`
- Plot a choropleth using `tmap`
- Add labels and legends

Summary

- Choose the right map for the data and audience
- Make thoughtful color and projection choices
- Use `tmap` for quick static/interactive maps
- Use `leaflet` for rich interactivity
- Access geographic data via `tigris` and `tidycensus`



End-of-Class Survey

 Fill out the end-of-class survey

~ This is the end of Lecture 3 ~